

US 114051 · SO 3 · NQF LEVEL 5 · 4 CREDITS

Chairing a Technical Practitioners Meeting



Rules the members own, the agenda followed step by step, everyone participating
— and clear decisions with owners and timeframes

TIME	SESSION	MODULE	QUALITY ASSURANCE
90-minute lesson · Self & Group	Friday, 11 Sep 2026 · 09h00 – 14h00	Module 1 · Personal Development	QCTO / MICT SETA

SPECIFIC OUTCOME 3 & ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

What you must be able to do

Chair a technical practitioners meeting. You will be assessed against these criteria:



Establish rules

The chair and members agree on rules and guidelines on behaviour.



Apply conventions

Agreed conventions applied throughout, per the standing procedures of the organisation.



Follow the agenda

The published agenda is followed item by item.



Enable participation

Active participation by all members to avoid or minimise conflict.



Prioritise & time-box

Topics prioritised; discussion time allocated by importance, urgency and complexity.



Land clear decisions

Decisions clear, accurate, time-framed and within the meeting's mandate.

The chairperson — the most important person in the room

- The chairperson sets the pace, keeps people on the topics, ensures democratic decisions are taken and that everyone is on board with them.
- Chairing is a great skill: teach members to chair and rotate the job so more people practise it — but use an experienced chairperson for important meetings.
- A good chairperson is an ACTIVE chairperson — not just keeping a list of speakers and letting them talk one after the other.
- Introduce each topic clearly and guide the discussion, especially when people start repeating points.
- When a discussion throws up opposing views, summarise the different positions and propose a way forward: a vote, a further discussion at another date, or a compromise most people can agree with.
- Ask the meeting to agree on the way forward — and apologise to those who still wanted to speak.

Open with rules the members own

ESTABLISH RULES & GUIDELINES

- Agree the rules in conjunction with the members at the start
- Set a cut-off time everyone agrees on — it encourages people to be brief
- How to get the floor, how long contributions may run
- How decisions will be taken — and what is in scope
- Agreed rules create buy-in and prevent procedural disputes

APPLY THE AGREED CONVENTIONS

- Run motions through moving, seconding and amending
- Follow the published agenda item by item
- Handle points of order, information and protection fairly
- Park unrelated issues and keep an eye on the clock
- The same rules for everyone — applied consistently

Running the agenda step by step

- Open the meeting, welcome everyone and check who is present — record apologies, and send round an attendance register if the group is large.
- Start on time, and make sure everyone knows who everyone else is — a quick go-round of names for newcomers.
- Minutes: circulate or read the previous meeting's minutes, give members the chance to add what was left out, and adopt them as an accurate record.
- Matters arising: work through the points from the previous minutes — tasks report back, deferred matters are discussed.
- Correspondence: read out or list the letters received, with the chairperson suggesting action on each.
- Other items: someone introduces each item as a discussion or a report — a report covers what was completed, the problems, and what still needs to be done.
- For each discussion: examine the issue, get everyone's ideas, arrive at a decision, delegate responsibility, and follow up to ensure completion.

Basic steps for chairing — decisions that stick

- Call on individuals to introduce or lead each agenda point, give everyone a chance to speak — and ensure no one dominates the discussion.
- Summarise the discussion clearly, restating the ideas and proposals put forward — without repeating everything that was said.
- Get agreement on what the decision is, and make sure everyone understands it.
- Delegate the duty of carrying out each decision — the responsible person must know exactly what to do, by when, and when to report back.
- Ensure everyone takes part in the discussions and the decision-making.
- Always set the date for the next meeting before this one ends.

Facilitation skills that make it work



Encourage discussion

Turn questions back to the group, ask open-ended questions, compliment ideas — let people say “ditto” instead of repeating.



Manage the traffic

Jot down speakers in order; let first-time speakers skip the queue; no second turn until everyone has spoken once.



Stay neutral

Don't use the chair to impose your own opinions — step aside if you feel strongly, speak last, and mark personal views as personal.



Watch the non-verbals

Look at speakers, lean forward, nod; make eye contact with people who need encouragement — spot the half-raised hand.



Use silence

Don't fear silence — it gives people a chance to collect their thoughts and often draws out hesitant comments.



Guide to closure

Restate comments, ask for clarification, summarise what is agreed and what is left, and call the decision when it's time.

Participation, priorities and staying on course

- Provide for active participation by ALL members — invite quiet members by name and draw the whole group into the discussion; that is how conflict is minimised.
- Prioritise topics and allocate discussion time according to importance, urgency, complexity and the agenda.
- If discussion strays off-topic, point it out and redirect it back on course; agree a time limit when a discussion threatens to run away.
- If the group is only repeating itself, restate and summarise the issues and ask if people are ready to decide — or table the matter, ask someone to bring more information, or form a committee.
- If a decision is too contentious, postpone it to the next meeting so people can think things over — and calm down.
- Ensure agreed decisions are clear, accurate, include a time frame for action, and are within the mandate of the type of meeting conducted.
- Take time at the end to process: what went well, lingering concerns — and END ON TIME; nothing makes people dread meetings more than overruns.

Managing difficult behaviours

Behaviour	What the chair does
The heckler	Aggressive and argumentative — stay calm, find merit in one point, express agreement, move on.
The one who won't shut up	Eager-beaver, show-off, well-informed or just talkative — wait for a breath, thank them, ask to hear from someone else; toss misstatements back to the group.
The cynic	May gripe at random or have a real complaint — point out the meeting seeks better ways by constructive cooperation; let a group member answer.
The silent one	Bored, shy or uncertain — ask directly for their opinion, show respect for their experience, encourage their first contribution; never force them.
The egos	Personalities clash — compliment their enthusiasm, ask for constructive solutions, emphasise points they agree on, throw a question to the rest.
The chatty couple	Side conversations — remind them of the debate, draw them back with an easy question and a recap of what was just discussed.
The one who is defiantly wrong	Confused or misinformed — tactfully restate their point to show the error, or leave the debate open for the group to correct it.

Your work for Specific Outcome 3



Chair a meeting

Role-play practical: chair a 10-minute technical meeting from a scenario card — observed evidence.



Questioning session

“Chairing a technical practitioners meeting” — typed answers, AI-marked.



Quiz 3

Preparing and chairing the meeting. 80%+ is competent.



Run the meeting — don't let the meeting run you.

Rules agreed with the members » the agenda followed step by step » everyone heard, no one dominating » difficult behaviour managed with skill » decisions that are clear, accurate, time-framed — and a meeting that ends on time.